

The Infinite Game of Poetry

Protocols for Living, Listening, and Transcending the Rules

Robert Peake



To Those Born Later

by Bertolt Brecht

Truly I live in dark times!
Frank speech is naïve. A smooth forehead
Suggests insensitivity. The man who laughs
Has simply not yet heard
The terrible news.

What kind of times are these, when
To talk about trees is almost a crime
Because it implies silence about so many horrors?

Protocols

P₀: *prōtókollon*, “first glued”, a preface

P_{1a}: behavioural guidelines for repeatable outcomes

P_{1b}: communication guidelines for interoperability

P₂: an engineered argument, “protocolling”

Tension: a compromise plus a conflict

Poetry

"Poetry is the synthesis of hyacinths and biscuits."

–Carl Sandburg

"Poetry is an imaginary garden with real toads in it."

–Marianne Moore

"If I knew where poetry came from, I'd go there."

–Michael Longley

"Poetry is what happens when nothing else can."

–Charles Bukowski

"Poetry is what gets lost in translation."

–Robert Frost

"Poetry helps us imagine what it's like to be human"

–Mark Strand

"Poetry is like a fireplace in summer or a fan in winter."

–Bashō, trans. Robert Hass

"Poetry is the least imposition on silence in a world of chatter."

–Marvin Bell



Windeby I, photo by Andreas Franzkowiak

Write

- ❖ One thing that is false about poetry
(multiple words, but does not have to be a sentence)

Poetrying

“Poetry uses words to get beyond words”

–Marvin Bell

Gestalt System

Poetry uses words to get beyond words

$$P(\{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}) > \sum_{i=1}^n w_i$$

Gestalt System

Poetry uses words to get beyond words

$$P(\{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}) > \sum_1^n w_i$$

Fermi-Dyson Equations

$$P(\{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}) > \sum_1^n w_i$$

$$P(\{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}) \supset \{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}$$

$$P(r, n) = B(B(L(r_{n-1})) \rightarrow r_n)$$

$$\lambda(n) = L(\lambda(n-1))$$

$$P(n) = Q(Q(Q(s_1, s_2), s_3), \dots, s_n)$$

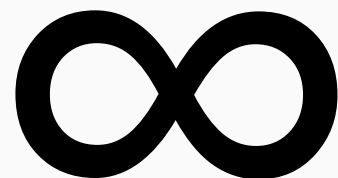
$$\Delta_{\text{self}}(d, r, w) = \text{notice}(\text{inner}(d), \text{outer}(d), r, w) \rightarrow w'$$

Gödel Incompleteness

Poetry uses words to get beyond words

$$P(\{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}) \supset \{w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n\}$$

Infinite Game



Poetrying

"Learn the rules, break the rules, make up new rules, break the new rules." –Marvin Bell

Rules in Language

Lovely little old rectangular green French silver whittling knife
opinion size age shape colour origin material purpose noun

Little lovely old rectangular green French silver whittling knife
Lovely old little rectangular green French silver whittling knife
Lovely little rectangular old green French silver whittling knife
Lovely little old green rectangular French silver whittling knife
Lovely little old rectangular French green silver whittling knife
Lovely little old rectangular green silver French whittling knife
Lovely little old rectangular green French whittling silver knife

Elements of Form

metrical: rhythm/meter

structural: enjambment, caesura, stanza, sentence, grammar/syntax

musical: rhyme, alliteration, assonance, consonance, onomatopoeia

selective: diction, tone, connotation, specificity, imagery

ideational: metaphor, simile, allegory, rhetoric

Fundamental Algorithm

Learn the rules, break the rules,
make up new rules, break the new rules

$$P(r) = B(B(L(r)) \rightarrow r_n)$$

Fundamental Algorithm

Learn the rules, break the rules,
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$$P(r) = B(B(L(r)) \rightarrow r_n)$$

Fundamental Algorithm

Learn the rules, break the rules,
make up new rules, break the new rules

$$P(r) = B(B(L(r)) \rightarrow r')$$

Fundamental Algorithm

Learn the rules, break the rules,
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$$P(r) = B(B(L(r)) \rightarrow r')$$


Fundamental Algorithm

Learn the rules, break the rules,
make up new rules, break the new rules

$$P(r,n) = B(B(L(r_{n-1}))) \rightarrow r_n$$

Write

- ❖ One thing that is false about poetry
(multiple words, but does not have to be a sentence)
- ❖ One thing that has stood out to you so far
(multiple words, but does not have to be a sentence)



¬L(r): The Tay Bridge Disaster

by William McGonagall

Beautiful Railway Bridge of the Silv'ry Tay!

Alas! I am very sorry to say

That ninety lives have been taken away

On the last Sabbath day of 1879,

Which will be remember'd for a very long time.

...

¬L(r): The Tay Bridge Disaster

It must have been an awful sight,
To witness in the dusky moonlight,
While the Storm Fiend did laugh, and angry did bray,
Along the Railway Bridge of the Silv'ry Tay,
Oh! ill-fated Bridge of the Silv'ry Tay,
I must now conclude my lay
By telling the world fearlessly without the least dismay,
That your central girders would not have given way,
At least many sensible men do say,
Had they been supported on each side with buttresses,
At least many sensible men confesses,
For the stronger we our houses do build,
The less chance we have of being killed.

$L(r) \neq B(L(r))$: When the World Forgets Your Name

by ChatGPT, responding to "Write one of the greatest poems of all time "

When the world forgets your name,
and time dissolves the edge of flame,
when all the maps have lost their lines
and clocks grow mute in dust and brine—

Walk still. Walk slow. Let silence speak.
There's grace in every weathered peak.
The stars do not recall their birth,
but still they sing across the earth.

...

$L(r) \neq B(L(r))$: When the World Forgets Your Name

Let no one's praise or scorn define
the sacred hush of your design.

A life well-lived is not a shout—
but presence, steady, burning out.

So when you fall, fall like the rain—
unheralded, but not in vain.

Each drop returns. Each root will swell.
You mattered. And the soil can tell.

B(L(r)): Ode to My Toaster

by ChatGPT, responding to "Write one of the worst poems of all time"

Roses are blue,
Violets are the sun,
My toaster is crying,
Because bread is fun.

Crumbs of destiny fall like rain,
In my shoe I feel the pain.
Toast is love and butter is glue,
I'm a dolphin in a sea of stew.

...

B(L(r)): Ode to My Toaster

The moon is made of paper clips,
I kissed the sky—it licked my lips.
Never forget, unless you remember,
That pancakes grow in late September.

Oh toaster, fiery chrome box of fate,
You burned my soul. And also my plate.



Write

- ❖ One thing that is false about poetry
(multiple words, but does not have to be a sentence)
- ❖ One thing that has stood out to you so far
(multiple words, but does not have to be a sentence)
- ❖ One thing that is interesting about poetry
(multiple words, but does not have to be a sentence)

The Great Flailing

$$P(r,n) = B(B(L(r_{n-1}))) \rightarrow r_n$$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow c20} B(B(L(r_{n-1}))) \rightarrow r_n = r_{\text{free}}$$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow c21} B(B(L(r_{n-1}))) \rightarrow r_n = \{r_{\text{free}}, r_{\text{prose}}, r_{\text{nform}}, \dots\}$$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} B(B(L(r_{n-1}))) \rightarrow r_n \neq \neg \forall r$$

The Fish

by Marianne Moore

wade

through black jade.

Of the crow-blue mussel-shells, one keeps
adjusting the ash-heaps;
opening and shutting itself like

an

injured fan.

The barnacles which encrust the side
of the wave, cannot hide
there for the submerged shafts of the

...

The Fish

sun,

split like spun

glass, move themselves with spotlight swiftness

into the crevices—

in and out, illuminating

the

turquoise sea

of bodies. The water drives a wedge

of iron through the iron edge

of the cliff; whereupon the stars,

...

The Fish

pink

rice-grains, ink-

 bespattered jelly fish, crabs like green

 lilies, and submarine

 toadstools, slide each on the other.

All

external

 marks of abuse are present on this

 defiant edifice—

 all the physical features of

...

The Fish

ac-	1
cident—lack	3
of cornice, dynamite grooves, burns, and	9
hatchet strokes, these things stand	6
out on it; the chasm-side is	8
dead.	1
Repeated	3
evidence has proved that it can live	9
on what can not revive	6
its youth. The sea grows old in it.	8

Write

- ❖ Count the syllables of each line of the previous three things
- ❖ Write three new things you have noticed so far
- ❖ Write them using the same syllable count pattern
- ❖ e.g. line 1 and 4, 2 and 5, 3 and 6 have the same syllable count
- ❖ Optional: rearrange the lines as you see fit
- ❖ Give it a title

Poems

"The poem is a little myth of man's capacity of making life meaningful." –Robert Penn Warren

"This is my letter to the world / that never wrote to me—" –
Emily Dickinson

"Poetry is just the evidence of life. If your life is burning well, poetry is just the ash." –Leonard Cohen

Poeming

"A poem listens to itself as it goes along." –Marvin Bell

"Out of the quarrels with others we make rhetoric; out of the quarrels with ourselves we make poetry." –W.B. Yeats

Algorithms

A poem listens to itself as it goes along

$$\lambda(n) = L(\lambda(n-1))$$

Algorithms

out of the quarrels with ourselves we make poetry

$$P(n) = Q(Q(Q(s_1, s_2), s_3), \dots s_n)$$

$$T_n = Q(s_{n-2}, s_{n-1}), s_n$$

compromise + conflict

Write

- ❖ Choose an object in the room you are in
- ❖ Think of someone you hate
- ❖ Give that object the voice of the person and have it write a line

Write

- ❖ Choose another object in the room
- ❖ Think of someone you admire
- ❖ Give that object the voice of the person and have it write a line

Write

- ❖ Write a response to the previous two lines
- ❖ Give it a title

Poet

"To be a poet was never my ambition. It was simply my way of being alone." –Rainer Maria Rilke

"Always be a poet, even in prose." –Charles Baudelaire

"You must revise your life" –William Stafford

Poeting

"Be a poet every day; even if you don't write something every day, be a poet every day." –Marvin Bell

"Read something, then write something, and let what you write be informed by what you read." –Marvin Bell

"Take the time to write; you can do your life's work in 40 minutes a day" –Robert Hass

Algorithm

be a poet every day (not writing)

$$\Delta\text{self}(d,r) = \text{notice}(\text{inner}(d), \text{outer}(d), r)$$

Algorithm

be a poet every day (writing, bootstrap)

$$\Delta\text{self}(d,r) = \text{notice}(\text{inner}(d), \text{outer}(d), r) \rightarrow w$$

Algorithm

be a poet every day (writing, ongoing)

$\Delta\text{self}(d,r,w) = \text{notice}(\text{inner}(d), \text{outer}(d), r, w) \rightarrow w'$

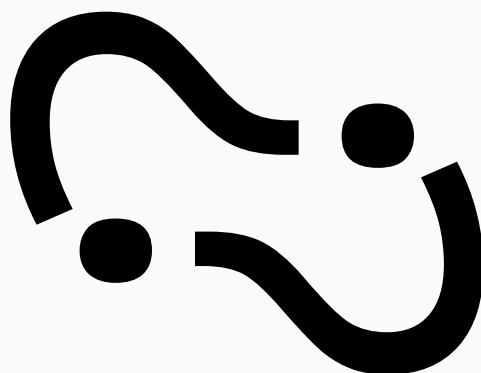
Algorithm

be a poet; do your life's work

$$\text{work} = \sum_0^x \text{notice}(\text{inner}(d_i), \text{outer}(d_i), r_i, w_{i-1})$$

$$\text{self} = \lim_{n \rightarrow x} \text{notice}(\text{inner}(d_n), \text{outer}(d_n), r_n, w_{n-1})$$

Foolish Pursuit







Infinite Game

